LESSON 6 · 3RD TERM · COLOR FUNDAMENTALS

Local Color vs Light Color

What the object is vs what the light does to it

Local color is the 'true' color of an object in neutral light: a red apple is red, a grey rock is grey. Light color is what you actually see — the color modified by the light source, shadow, and atmosphere. Painting what you see, not what you know, is the key to convincing color.

KEY CONCEPTS

The Problem with Local Color

Beginners paint local color: they know the apple is red, so they paint it red everywhere. But the lit part of the apple is warm orange-red; the shadow side is cool, desaturated purple-red. Neither is 'just red'.

What Light Does

Light adds its own color to everything it touches. Sunlight warms and saturates the lit areas. Blue sky cools and desaturates the shadows. Reflected light from a red floor bounces red into adjacent shadows. All of these modify the local color.

The Procedure

1) Identify the local color. 2) Ask: what does the light source do to it (warm, cool, bright, dim)? 3) Ask: what do the shadows do to it (cool, desaturate, darken)? 4) Ask: what reflected light affects the shadow side?

Training Your Eye

Look at your subject and ask: 'What color is this actually?' — not what you know it is, but what color you'd need to mix to match it. This perceptual shift is the core skill of all color painting.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Paint an apple under warm lamp light. Never paint 'red' — only what you actually see.
2. Paint a white egg under colored light. Identify the local color vs. the perceived color.
3. Do a color study of a single object, mixing every value and temperature you observe.

FURTHER READING

- **Proko – Local vs Light Color**
  https://youtu.be/AZhO4VjQUPE
- **Ctrl+Paint – Seeing Color**